MINORITY RAPPORT

There are plenty of schemes for minorities, but implementing them is a different matter

By Kaushik Deka

Mukhtar Abbas Naqvi
Minister of Minority Affairs



GETTY IMAGES

THERE ARE SIX communities in the care of the ministry of minority affairs—Muslim, Christian, Sikh, Buddhist, Jain and Parsi. Tasked with their socio-economic uplift, it's the nodal ministry for the implementation of the PM's 15-point programme for minority welfare. The programme aims to achieve four broad objectives: enhancing opportunities for education, ensuring an equitable share in economic activities/employment, improving living conditions and preventing communal disharmony and violence. In addition, the ministry implements the Pradhan Mantri Jan Vikas Karyakram, which aims to enhance social infrastructure in identified minority concentration areas. The ministry's budget has seen an increase of 60 per cent, from Rs 3,130 crore in 2013-14 to Rs 5,020 crore in 2022-23. Critics say the allocation—0.15 per cent of the total budget for a ministry taking care of 19 per cent of India's population—is too low. The government's counter is that minorities also avail benefits under other welfare schemes. ■

WHAT'S DONE

- The PM Jan Vikas Karyakram has been extended to all districts
- Education funding up from Rs 2,351 crore (2020–21) to Rs 2,515 crore (2021–22)

CHALLENGES AHEAD

- Only 40 per cent earmarked for eight schemes for the educational empowerment of minorities could be spent in 2021–22 due to the pandemic

VIKRAM SHARMA



Arjun Munda
Minister of Tribal Affairs

TRIBAL AFFAIRS

A FINE BALANCE

Preserving traditions while encouraging development is the central focus

By Sonali Acharjee

PROMOTING TRIBAL development while protecting tribal culture has always been a tightrope walk. Under Union Minister for Tribal Affairs Arjun Munda, this effort has seen a greater push. The ministry's budget has risen from Rs 3,850 crore in 2014-15 to Rs 7,484 crore in 2021-22. This has been used to drive education, but entrepreneurship has also been on the ministry's agenda. To protect tribal areas, awareness and advocacy of the Forest Rights Act, 2006 has also been an important focus area for the ministry. ■

WHAT'S DONE

- 84 new schools in construction
- 36,000 model tribal villages in development

CHALLENGES AHEAD

- Access to quality healthcare
- Improving the literacy rate
- Tribal displacement